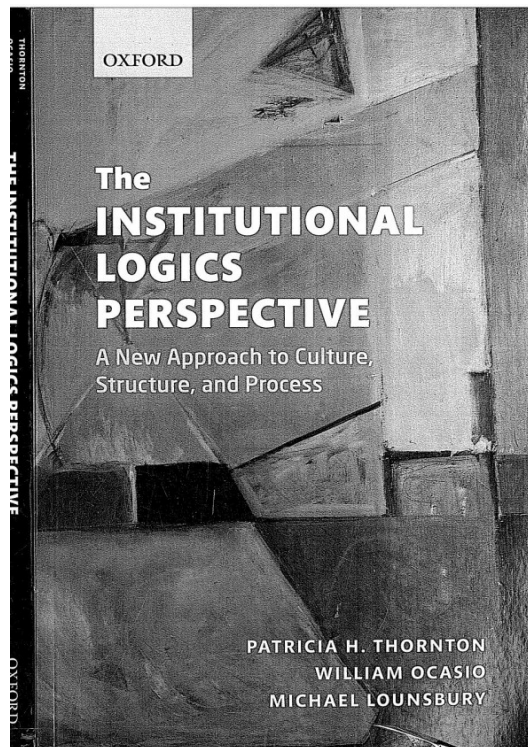


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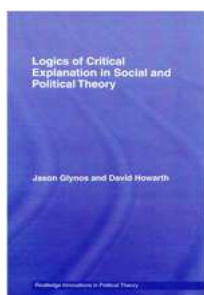
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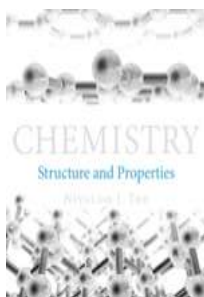
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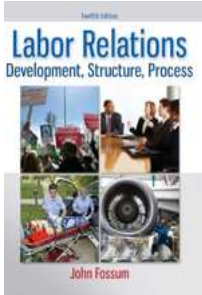
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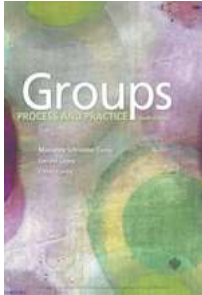
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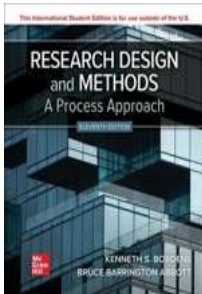
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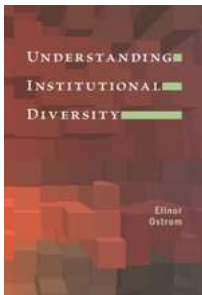
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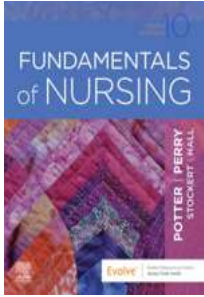
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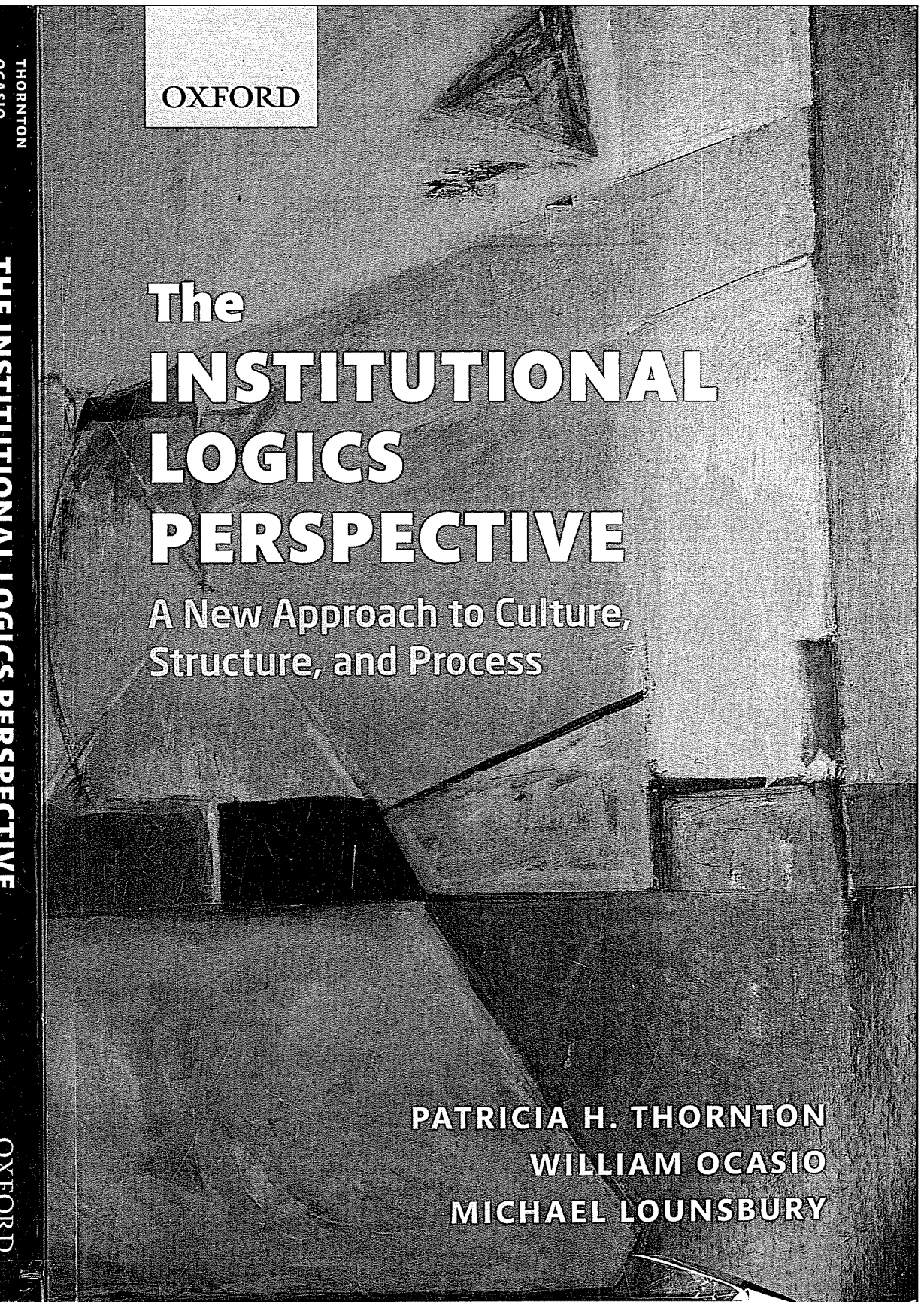
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The INSTITUTIONAL LOGICS PERSPECTIVE

**A New Approach to Culture,
Structure, and Process**

**PATRICIA H. THORNTON
WILLIAM OCASIO
MICHAEL LOUNSBURY**

THORNTON
OCASIO

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Preface

Neoinstitutional theory, beginning with the seminal work of Meyer and Rowan, Zucker, and DiMaggio and Powell, led to the widespread proliferation of empirical research and theoretical development in the field of organization studies. Despite its many achievements, the seeds of discontent with neoinstitutional theory have been germinating for quite some time and have found fertile ground for increasing research in institutional logics. This began with Friedland and Alford's critique and rudimentary statement that introduced the concept of institutional logics in 1991. Two of the authors of this book, Pat Thornton and Willie Ocasio, along with Heather Haveman, Huggy Rao, and Barbara Townley, were early developers of the institutional logics concept. Nevertheless, this work had not yet incarnated into a theoretical perspective.

In 2002 Pat, Willie, and Mike spearheaded a symposium at the Academy of Management with the help of Walter Powell entitled, "Beyond the Taken for Granted: Institutions, Cognition, and Agency." Pat continued to apply the concept of institutional logics to organizational decisions and was an early developer in integrating the inter-institutional system with tool kits and cognitive schema, accumulating a systematic body of theoretical and empirical research that was combined in a meta-analysis in her 2004 book. Meanwhile, Mike continued to make important extensions, particularly in the context of competing institutional logics and community as an institutional logic. Concurrently, Willie researched the relationships between attention, sensemaking, vocabularies, and changing institutional logics. Within the last decade, it became increasingly clear that a body of work on institutional logics had taken shape that could guide the scope of institutional analysis.

The year 2006 was a watershed moment as, with renewed resources and leadership at the University of Alberta, a cadre of faculty well versed in institutional analysis issued a call for conference papers on the state of growth of neoinstitutional theory—boldly challenging if neoinstitutional theory was dead. Pat responded with a presentation on "Taking Stock of Theory and Empirical Research on Institutional Logics." The conference presentations motivated the highly influential volume on organizational institutionalism edited by Royston Greenwood, Christine Oliver, Kerstin

Sahlin-Andersson, and Roy Suddaby that hit the market in 2008 with momentum. In this volume, two of us contributed a review article on institutional logics as metatheory—signaling research on institutional logics as a core concept that was in significant ways distinct from neoinstitutional theory. It was a new orienting strategy in institutional analysis—a perspective in its own right.

Concomitantly, in 2008 a conference at the University of Arizona was organized to celebrate the 25th anniversary of the publication of DiMaggio and Powell 1983. At this conference, graduate students asked, “What is the next stage of development of neoinstitutional theory?” At a 2009 Alberta conference, the three of us met offline with the idea of developing this co-authored book to offer our answer to this question—institutional logics as a distinct perspective that builds on, yet departs from, neoinstitutional theory. Our objective is not an expanded literature review. We seek instead to formalize the perspective, analyze and explain its roots, develop new theory, and show how it solves critical problems for neoinstitutional theory, and institutional analysis more broadly.

Our aim is not to revive neoinstitutional theory, but to transform it. Recognizing both its strengths, the original insights on how macro structures and culture shape organizations, and its weaknesses—limited capacity to explain agency and the micro foundations of institutions, institutional heterogeneity, and change—the institutional logics perspective provides a new approach that incorporates macro structure, culture, and agency, through cross-level processes (society, institutional field, organization, interactions, and individuals) that explain how institutions both enable and constrain action.

While the perspective we present in this book is, of course, shaped by our own views, it both builds on and seeks to further stimulate the growing work on institutional logics by many scholars that we review in this book. Our aim ultimately is to build a community of scholars. To help do so, we organized a Professional Development Workshop at the 2009 Academy of Management meetings in Chicago entitled, “Cultivator: Theory, Methods, and Research in Institutional Logics.” We elicited the help of Rudy Durand, Mary Ann Glynn, Candy Jones, and Barbara Townley. In 2011, Mike spearheaded a follow-up with a European Group on Organization Studies (EGOS) track on Institutional Logics in Gothenburg, Sweden (July 2011) that attracted one hundred submissions, and where each of us first presented chapters from this book. We thank Renate Meyer for helping us organize this track.

As the scholarly community continues to build this new perspective, we are excited by the opportunities for contributions from multiple disciplines and

by the progress in moving institutional theory forward in multiple directions that conceptualize culture, structure, and process; restoring the sensibilities of the role of actors and structures while revealing multi- and cross-level processes and mechanisms.

Patricia H. Thornton, Durham, North Carolina

William Ocasio, Evanston, Illinois

Michael Lounsbury, Edmonton, Canada

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Table of Contents

<i>List of Figures</i>	xiii
<i>List of Tables</i>	xiv
1. Introduction to the Institutional Logics Perspective	1
Introduction	1
Institutional Logics as an Analytical Framework	2
Aims of the Book	4
Analytical Style of the Book	5
Institutional Analysis as Interdisciplinary	5
Pointing the Way to a New Approach	6
Social Structure and Action	6
Institutions as Material and Symbolic	10
Institutions as Historically Contingent	12
Institutions at Multiple Levels of Analysis	13
Contents of the Book	15
Precursors	15
Macro—Societal Level	16
Micro and Meso—Individual and Organization Levels	16
Micro and Macro—Individual and Societal Levels	16
Meso and Macro—Organization and Institutional Field Levels	17
Meso and Macro—Institutional Field and Societal Levels	17
Synthesis	17
Conclusion	18
2. Precursors to the Institutional Logics Perspective	20
Introduction	20
Theories of Isomorphism	21
Variant: Micro Level	23
Elaboration: From Societal Culture to Field Structure	24
Elaboration: Origin, Reproduction, Disappearance	28
Variant: Logic of Instrumentalism, of Appropriateness	29
Variant: From Structural to Cognitive and Cultural	30
Variants: Logics of Action	33
Integration: Three Pillars and Carriers of Institutions	35

Table of Contents

Institutional Pillars	36
Institutional Carriers	39
Proliferation: Institutional Logics	40
Variant: A Focus on Normative Dimensions	46
Discussion and Conclusion	47
Appendix: Comparison of Propositions:	48
J. W. Meyer and Rowan (1977)	48
DiMaggio and Powell (1983)	48
3. Defining the Interinstitutional System	50
Introduction	50
Definitional Differences	51
The Interinstitutional System as Ideal Type	52
Institutional Orders: The X-Axis	53
Institutional Orders: The Y-Axis	54
Partial Autonomy: Cognitive and Organizational Loose Coupling	57
Partial Autonomy: Near-Decomposability of Institutional Orders	59
Definition of Institutional Fields	61
Cultural Content: Cells of the X, Y Axes	62
Cultural Space in Society	62
Cultural Effects on Power and Agency	64
Proliferation: Rearranging the Institutional Orders	66
Variant: Community as an Institutional Order	68
Discussion and Conclusion	72
Appendix	74
4. Microfoundations of Institutional Logics	76
A Model of Human Behavior: Situated, Embedded, Boundedly	
Intentional Behavior	78
Modeling the Microfoundations	80
Dynamic Constructivism	83
An Integrative Model of the Microfoundations of Institutional Logics	84
Social Identities, Goals, and Schemas	85
Social Identities	85
Goals	86
Schemas	88
Focus of Attention	89
Top-Down Effects of Institutional Logics and	
Organizational Practices	91
Bottom-Up Environmental Stimuli	91
Availability, Accessibility, and Activation	92
Automatic and Controlled Attentional Processes	93
From Activation to Social Interaction	93

From Social Interactions to Organizational Identities and Practices	95
Decision Making	95
Sensemaking	96
Mobilization	97
Implications of the Model of Microfoundations	98
Conclusion	102
5. Stability and Change in the Interinstitutional System	103
Introduction	103
Evolutionary-Systems Level	104
Historical Interdependence of Institutional Orders	105
Individual-Societal-Level Effects on Institutional Change	106
Cultural Entrepreneurship	107
Case Narrative: Penney Segregates Family, Blends Religion and Corporation	111
Case Narrative: Sperling Segregates the Professions and Blends the Market and Corporation	112
Case Narrative: Ettinger Blends Family, State, Market, and Corporation	114
Cross-Narrative Discussion	117
Discussion	119
Conclusion	125
6. Dynamics of Organizational Practices and Identities	128
Introduction	128
From Social Interaction to Practices and Organizational Identities	131
The Dynamics of Practices and Identities in Organizations	133
The Dynamics of Practices and Identities Across Organizations	141
Conclusion	147
7. The Emergence and Evolution of Field-Level Logics	148
Introduction	148
A Model of Cultural Emergence	150
Societal and External Logics	150
Symbolic Representations: Theories, Frames, and Narratives	152
Resource Environments and their Effects on Institutional Logics	157
Vocabularies of Practice and the Emergence of Field-Level Logics	158
Evolution and Change in Field-Level Logics	161
Conclusion	168
8. Implications of the Institutional Logics Perspective	170
Implications for Other Disciplines and Substantive Research Domains	172
Historical and Comparative Analysis of Institutions	173

Table of Contents

Institutional Complexity	175
Social Movements	175
Cultural and Institutional Entrepreneurship	176
Institutional Work	179
Organizational Identity	180
Organizational Design	181
Strategy	182
Microprocesses	183
Methods of Analysis	184
Conclusion	185
<i>References</i>	187
<i>Index</i>	221

List of Figures

1.1	A Cross-Level Model of Institutional Logics Combining Micro-Macro and Macro-Micro	15
4.1	A Macro-Macro Model of Institutional Logics	81
4.2	Institutional Logics and Attention	81
4.3	Coleman Diagram	82
4.4	A Cross-Level Model of Institutional Logics Combining Macro-Micro and Micro-Macro	85
6.1	Endogenous Dynamics of Practices and Identities Within Organizations	136
6.2	Endogenous Dynamics of Practices and Identities Across Organizations	143
7.1	Cultural Emergence of Field-Level Institutional Logics	151

List of Tables

2.1	Theory of Isomorphism and Loose Coupling: Conditions for the Production of Rationalized Myths of Organization Structure	22
2.2	Theory of Isomorphism: Sources of Organizational Rationalization	26
2.3	The Old and the New Institutionalisms	32
2.4a	Varying Emphases: Three Pillars of Institutions	36
2.4b	Three Pillars of Institutions	37
2.4c	Three Pillars of Institutions	37
2.5a	Institutional Pillars and Carriers	39
2.5b	Institutional Pillars and Carriers	39
2.6	Interinstitutional System of Institutional Orders: Symbolic and Material Content of Culture	43
3.1	Interinstitutional System Ideal Types	56
3.2	Revised Interinstitutional System Ideal Types	73
5.1	Interinstitutional System Ideal Types	108
5.2	Individuals Visualize Problems and Innovations by Transposing Logics from Different Institutional Orders	109
7.1	Typology of Change in Field-Level Institutional Logics	164

Introduction to the Institutional Logics Perspective

Introduction

This book is about how the institutional logics perspective transforms institutional theory. We three authors have come together to meld our insights in analyzing the origins, interpretation, and growth of this rapidly developing literature. In the process, we elaborate and extend its theoretical and methodological reach and suggest new ideas for future research. While we include substantial literature reviews to illustrate our arguments, a comprehensive survey of the literature is not our purpose. Instead, our aims are twofold pronged: to produce a primer that imparts a programmatic statement on the institutional logics perspective that distinguishes it from neoinstitutional theory and to synthesize and propose novel theory to further flesh out the metatheory initially suggested by Friedland and Alford (1991). Ultimately, advancing theory construction and testing involves a process of discovery that is best accomplished by sharing ideas among a community of junior and senior scholars. Thus, our purpose is to elaborate and pollinate the core ideas of the institutional logics perspective with hopes of further galvanizing a community of scholars to develop new theory and empirical research.

In this chapter we first introduce the institutional logics perspective as an analytical framework for institutional analysis. Second, we describe the overall aims of the book and the analytical style in which the material is presented. Third, we briefly discuss the suitability of institutional logics for interdisciplinary integration of institutional research across the social sciences. Last, we discuss the purpose of four central metatheoretical principles of the institutional logics perspective and introduce an integrated model of the cross-level effects that will be discussed in detail in the following chapters.

The concept of institutional logics is intuitively attractive, but arguably difficult to define and even harder to apply in an analytically useful manner.

Thornton and Ocasio (2008) define an institutional logic as the socially constructed, historical patterns of cultural symbols and material practices, including assumptions, values, and beliefs, by which individuals and organizations provide meaning to their daily activity, organize time and space, and reproduce their lives and experiences. While institutional analysis has a long history in the social sciences, institutional logics researchers are now experimenting with new theory and methods that address long-standing problems of interest in the social sciences. We craft a synthetic and extended analysis of institutional logics research and develop significant elaborations and novel theory. We present this material in an advanced yet user-friendly analytical framework for scholars engaged in the many provocative questions about how we are all affected by the world of institutions—questions of relevance across the social sciences.

Institutional Logics as an Analytical Framework

The institutional logics perspective is a metatheoretical framework for analyzing the interrelationships among institutions, individuals, and organizations in social systems. It aids researchers interested in questions of how individual and organizational actors are influenced by their situation in multiple social locations in an interinstitutional system, for example the institutional orders of the family, religion, state, market, professions, and corporation. Conceptualized as a theoretical model, each institutional order of the interinstitutional system distinguishes unique organizing principles, practices, and symbols that influence individual and organizational behavior. Institutional logics represent frames of reference that condition actors' choices for sense-making, the vocabulary they use to motivate action, and their sense of self and identity. The principles, practices, and symbols of each institutional order differentially shape how reasoning takes place and how rationality is perceived and experienced.

The origin of the theoretical and empirical research that we know today as the institutional logics perspective was first presented by Friedland and Alford in 1991 as a chapter in an edited volume that ironically attempted to solidify and redirect a research program in quite a different direction—on structural and cognitive isomorphism of organizational fields (Powell and DiMaggio 1991). The ideas in Friedland and Alford's chapter were later drawn upon by scholars examining how institutional logics moderated the selection theory of organizations (Haveman and Rao 1997) and how institutional logics moderated the attention of organizations in making strategic decisions (Thornton and Ocasio 1999). While not part of Friedland and Alford's (1991) chapter, it is noteworthy that important precursors to the institutional logics perspective

had been developing with the work on logics and practice (Bourdieu 1977), corporate institutional logics (Jackall 1988), interpretive schemes (Greenwood and Hinings 1988), conceptions of control (Fligstein 1985, 1987, 1990), and dominant logics as filters on attention (Pralhad and Bettis 1986).

Now, more than ten years hence, the institutional logics perspective has coalesced into a vibrant community of scholars, and is recognized as a core perspective in sociology and organization theory (Greenwood et al. 2008). Research in this fast-forming arena has been conducted in a variety of commercial and public domains such as savings and loan organizations (Haveman and Rao 1997), universities (Townley 1997), book publishing companies (Thornton and Ocasio 1999; Thornton 2001, 2002), health care organizations (Scott et al. 2000), French cuisine (Rao, Monin, and Durand 2003), equity markets (Zajac and Westphal 2004), symphony orchestras (Glynn and Lounsbury 2005), mutual funds (Lounsbury 2007), banking (Marquis and Lounsbury 2007), architects (C. Jones and Livne-Tarandach 2008), medical education (Dunn and Jones 2010), microfinance (Battilana and Dorado 2010), and shareholder value (R. E. Meyer and Höllerer 2010), among others.

Friedland and Alford (1991) initially gained the attention of a handful of scholars with their critique of the deficits of organization and neoinstitutional theory for not situating “actors” in a societal context. As we will discuss in subsequent chapters, their critique continues to be the wellspring of fertile ideas in need of further development. They argued that society and social relations are not just about the diffusion of material structures, but also about culture and the symbolic. They posited not a theory of environmental effects on organizations, but instead a metatheory of institutions that includes individuals and organizations—with more than enough import to reach across the social sciences.

Friedland and Alford's (1991) critique covered much more: It asked why network theory doesn't explain why people are connected, what they are likely to say, and why power and status do not have universal effects. It railed against rational-choice theory, arguing that the meaning of rationality varies by institutional order—within the sphere of the market, sensemaking occurs through the lens of self-interest; but under the influence of the professions it does not or does so in a tempered way, for example through concerns over personal reputation, professional association, and quality of craft. Their view of society as constituted by multiple institutional orders helps us to understand the broader array of organizing by both people and organizations. Their critique also marked political sociology and by implication political science in the sense that they argued that the meanings of power and resources vary by institutional order. Self-interest is not generally applicable across institutional settings. Instead, the institutional logics perspective is fundamentally about how to specify the countervailing and moderating effects on self-interest and

